

What Makes a Hero Truly Epic?



EPIC OF KINGS

JUL 01, 2026



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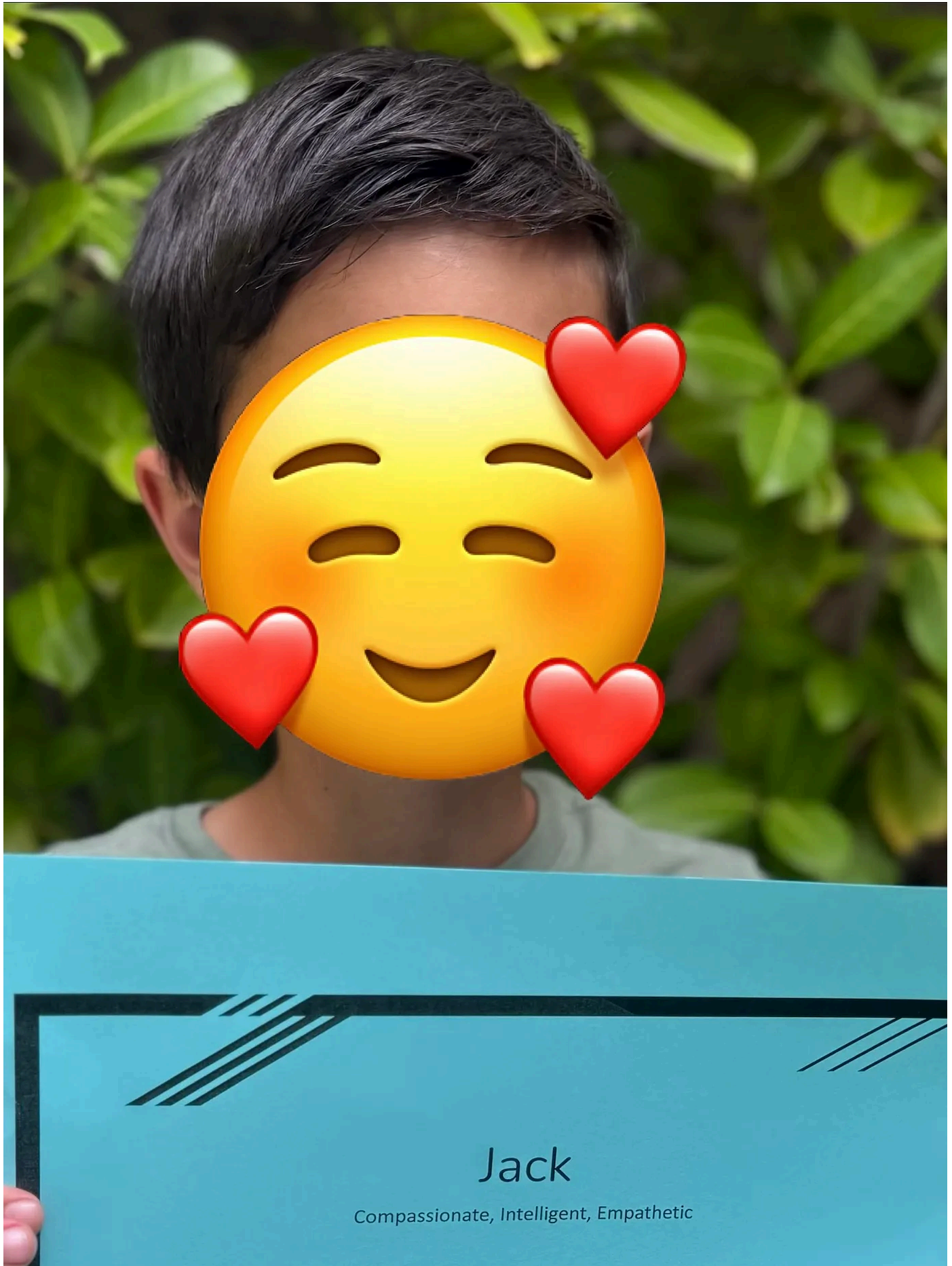
Happy Summer guys!

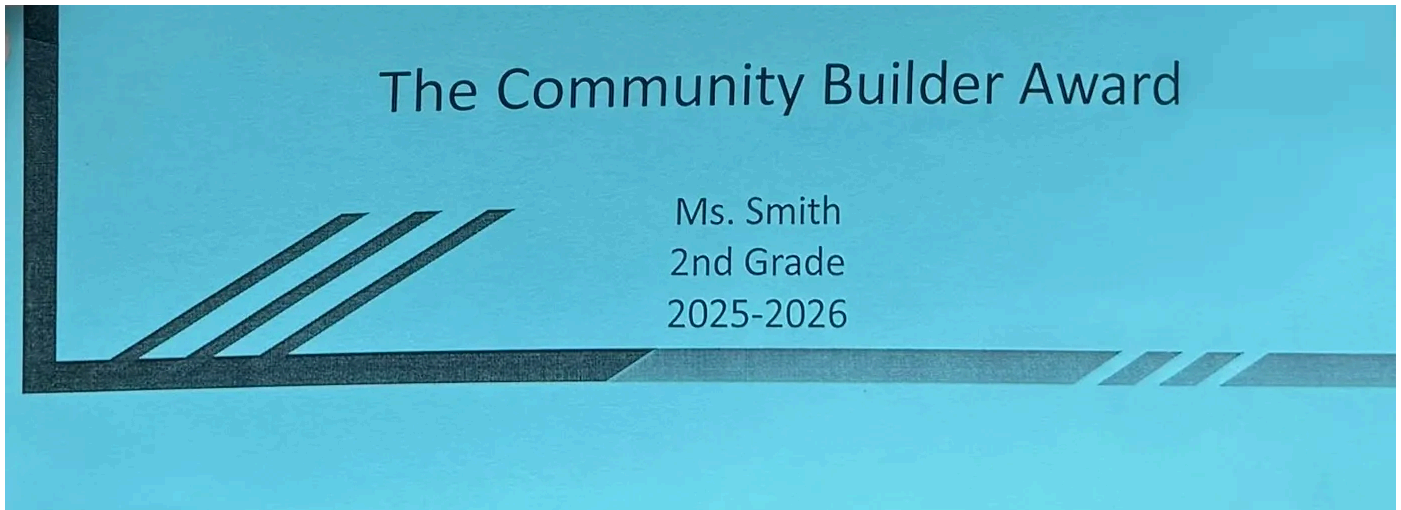
HUGE announcement!!! Today is July 1, 2026, and epicofkings.com is LIVE!!!

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work.

I'm SO excited that people can finally see everything we've been working on! The site has hero stories, villains, kings, family trees, maps, games, and lots of other cool stuff. I really hope it helps more people discover the *Shahnameh* because it's AWESOME. Check it out and let me know what you think!

It's been a busy couple of weeks for me. I finished second grade, and I've had camps and playdates almost every day. Plus, I've been watching World Cup games whenever I can! Summer has been really fun so far!





On the last day of school, my teacher gave every kid a special award. Mine was the Community Builder Award. She said it's because I'm "compassionate, intelligent, and empathetic." Then she wrote something in my yearbook that made my day. She wrote that I'm the most compassionate person she knows. Wow. I think that's the coolest compliment ever. Because what's the point of being smart if you're not also kind? I hope people always think of me that way.

And that brings us to today's question...

What makes a hero truly epic?

When most people think of heroes, they probably imagine someone who's super strong or super brave. Those things definitely matter. But after reading the *Shahnameh*, I realized that's not enough. Some super strong people make very bad choices. Like Afrasiyab. He's super powerful, but he's still the worst guy! And sometimes the greatest heroes aren't even the strongest ones.

So here are the things I think every truly epic hero has:

1. Bravery

This one is obvious. How can you be a hero if you never take any risks?

Rostam was brave even when he was only eight years old. A giant white elephant was on a rampage, and Rostam stopped it with just a swing of his mace. I bet Rostam was SCARED. Being brave doesn't mean you're never scared. It just means you do the right thing anyway.

2. Cleverness

Sometimes your brain is your best weapon.

When Akvan Div grabbed Rostam and asked if he wanted to be thrown onto the mountains or into the sea, Rostam figured out that the Div planned to do the opposite of whatever he answered. So he said the mountains... because he actually wanted the sea. His trick saved his life!

3. Good Judgment

Zal warned King Kay Kavus not to invade Mazandaran because he knew it was way dangerous. The king ignored him, and everything went horribly wrong. But here's the thing... Kay Kavus was brave. He just had bad judgment. So you actually need both. The best heroes also know when *not* to fight.

4. Strong Values

When the evil king Zahhak, who had two serpents growing from his shoulders, made his nobles sign a paper saying he was a good and fair king, the hero Kaveh ripped the paper up instead. Then he raised his blacksmith's apron on a spear like a flag and started a whole rebellion! Standing up for what's right isn't always easy, but heroes do it anyway.

5. Resilience

Everybody gets knocked down sometimes. Even heroes. The question is... do they ever get back up?

Zal was abandoned as a baby because of his white hair and skin and raised by the Simorgh. So yeah, he was basically raised by a giant magic bird! He could have given up. Instead, he became one of Persia's wisest men and raised Rostam, the greatest hero in the *Shahnameh*!

6. Compassion

I saved this one for last because I think it's the most important. Heroes aren't selfish. They care about other people. I think that's one of the reasons why everybody loves them.

For example, the Simorgh didn't have to rescue baby Zal. She could have just flown away. Instead, she chose kindness. Without her, there would have been no Zal. And without Zal... there would have been no Rostam.

Zal raised Rostam with that same kindness... and it showed. One time, a stable boy accidentally let Rostam's horse Rakhsh wander away. The boy was terrified because he thought Rostam would be furious. Instead, Rostam realized the boy had made an honest mistake. He showed the stable boy mercy.

Rostam also isn't happy when people die, even his enemies after a battle. And when Rostam himself was dying, he couldn't stop worrying about his horse Rakhsh, who was also dying right next to him. Oh man... that's another story where I had to fold the pages over because it was just WAY too sad.

Anyway, that got me thinking. Maybe what makes a hero truly epic isn't being the strongest person. Maybe it's using your strength to help other people.

What about you? Which hero trait do you think matters most?

Thanks for reading. See you next time!

Jack

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